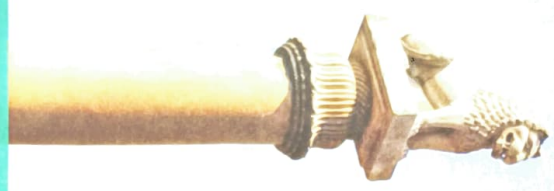


14/6/24



Tapestry of the Past

6. The First Indian Empire — the Mauryas



IN THIS CHAPTER, YOU WILL...

- Understand the factors that led to the emergence of the first empire in India.
- Study the key features of this new empire.
- Learn about the greatest ruler of this empire — Ashoka.

CONNECTIONS TO OUR LIFE

- The story of Ashoka's life teaches us how our actions can have a big impact on our lives.
- The ideas of peace and compassion spread by Ashoka continue to be relevant to our lives even today.
- Some of our national symbols today are from the period of Ashoka's rule.

BIG IDEA

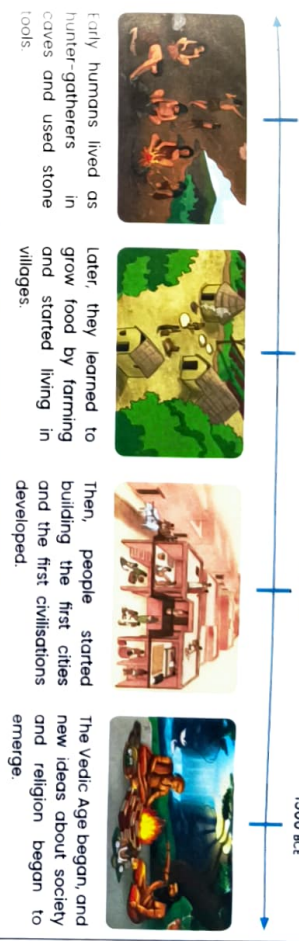
The Mauryan Empire was the first empire in India's history. It was the beginning of a long period in which powerful kingdoms and empires ruled over different parts of the country.

LET'S BEGIN

In Class 6, we explored our past, from the early humans to the Vedic Age. Let's quickly recap some of the major changes that took place.

ACTIVITY 1

Discuss with your partner one interesting thing you remember about each of the following events:



We also learned that during the Later Vedic Age, small kingdoms called *janapadas* started to form. Later, some of these small kingdoms grew into 16 bigger kingdoms called *mahajanapadas*. Around 600 BCE, four of these *mahajanapadas* grew more important than the others. One of these kingdoms, called Magadha, grew into India's first empire — the Mauryan Empire. We will learn about the Mauryan Empire in this chapter. But as we start our journey into the past this year, we will learn about an important tool that is used in the study of the past — periodisation.

6.1 PERIODISATION OF HISTORY

Historical Periods

How do historians keep track of dates and events across time?

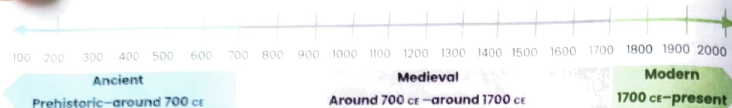
To keep dates and events organised, historians have broken time into periods. Just like your school schedule is organised into class periods, history is organised into specific periods. We have learned about two periods in Class 6 — prehistory and history. This division is based on when humans learned to write.



Historians also organise history into three periods in another way. This is based on features like the beliefs of the people, social structures, or the ruling powers at that time. The names of these three periods are the **ancient period**, the **medieval period**, and the **modern period**. Look at the timeline on the next page to understand how historians have divided Indian history into these three periods.

KEYWORDS

ancient: the oldest time period (prehistory to 700 c.)
 medieval: the period of time from 700 c. to the present



The change from one period to another is often marked by important events in history. For example, the end of the ancient period is marked by the reign of an important ruler called Harsha, whom we will learn about in Chapter 8. This also marked the beginning of the medieval period. Similarly, the change from the medieval to the modern period is marked by another important event which we will study in Class 8. Now, let's go back to the ancient period and the Mauryan Empire.

6.2 RISE OF THE MAURYAN EMPIRE

Before we start learning about the Mauryan Empire, we need to understand what an empire is and how it is different from a kingdom.

A **kingdom** is a small area of land ruled by a king or queen.

An **empire** is a large area of land ruled by a single powerful leader called an emperor or empress. It is much bigger than a kingdom.

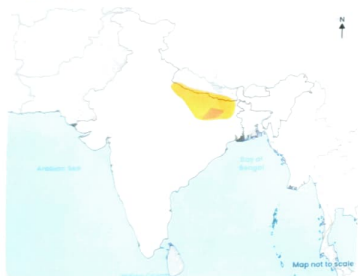


Fig. 6.1: The kingdom of Magadha

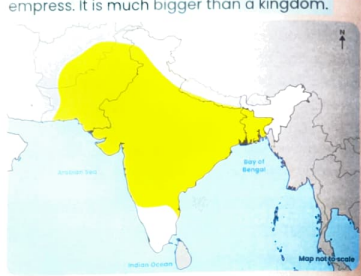


Fig. 6.2: The Mauryan Empire

So, how did a kingdom like Magadha grow into India's first empire? Let us travel back in time to find out.

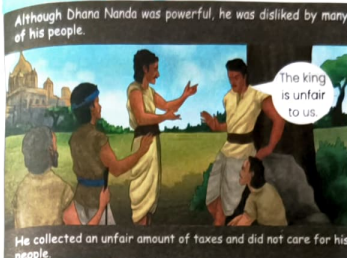
Around 338 BCE, a powerful kingdom called Macedonia emerged in Greece in present-day Europe. Alexander, the ruler of Macedonia, wanted to expand his empire by conquering more and more lands. So, he set off on a series of wars that took him from Greece towards India. Alexander was a skilled military leader. He managed to defeat the local rulers of several kingdoms in northwestern India and take over their kingdoms.

Meanwhile, in India, Magadha had become a powerful and prosperous kingdom under a ruler named Dhana Nanda. The kingdom had ample water from river Ganga and fertile land for agriculture. It was a centre of trade. It also had iron ore for weapons for a strong army.

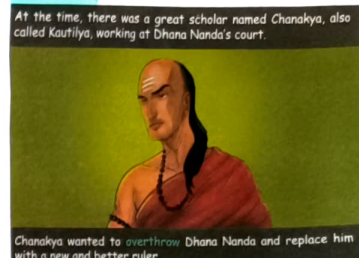
Alexander wanted to conquer Magadha as well. However, after years of war, his soldiers were tired. They were also worried about facing Magadha's powerful army. So, they refused to fight any more battles, and Alexander had to return. He appointed governors to rule the kingdoms he had conquered. Around the same time, some important changes started to take place in Magadha.

KEYWORDS

governors: officials appointed to rule a town or region



One day, Chanakya came across a young boy named Chandragupta. He was impressed by the boy's intelligence.



Chanakya wanted to overthrow Dhana Nanda and replace him with a new and better ruler. Chanakya trained Chandragupta in warfare and statecraft. He helped Chandragupta build an army, defeat Dhana Nanda, and become the ruler of Magadha in 321 BCE.

By 305 BCE, Chandragupta Maurya expanded his empire by conquering several kingdoms in the northwest that had become weak after Alexander's attacks. He was succeeded by his son and grandson. Read the timeline and observe the maps below to see how the empire grew under Chandragupta and his grandson, Ashoka.

KEYWORDS

overthrow: to remove from power by force
ways and means of fighting a war
statecraft: skills in managing the affairs of a kingdom or an empire

Chandragupta Maurya
(321 BCE–297 BCE)

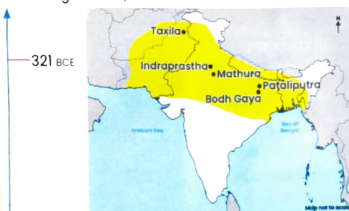


Fig. 6.3: The Mauryan Empire under Chandragupta Maurya

Bindusara
(Son of Chandragupta Maurya)
(297 BCE–273 BCE)

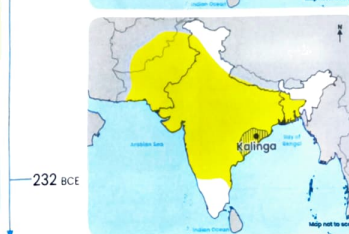


Fig. 6.4: The Mauryan Empire under Bindusara

Ashoka
(Son of Bindusara)
(268 BCE–232 BCE)

Did you notice that Chandragupta Maurya, Bindusara, and Ashoka all belonged to the same family? Together, they ruled over the Mauryan Empire for a long time. They belonged to the Mauryan dynasty. **A dynasty is a family of rulers who rule over a country, a kingdom, or an empire one after another.**

6.3 ASHOKA THE GREAT

Of all the emperors in the Mauryan dynasty, Emperor Ashoka is widely regarded as the greatest ruler. **He is even given the title of 'Ashoka the Great' by historians.** Why is he considered great? To answer this question, we must first learn more about Ashoka's life.

We know that **Ashoka was the son of King Bindusara, and he came to power in 268 BCE.** Like Alexander, **Ashoka wanted to expand his empire and become the most powerful ruler in India.** He fought wars with many kingdoms to expand his empire. Kalinga (as seen in Fig. 6.4) was one such kingdom. The Mauryan emperors had been trying to conquer Kalinga for a long time, but they had not been successful so far.



Fig. 6.5: Ashoka felt regret at the bloodshed caused by the war with Kalinga.

In Class 6, we learned about Buddha's *dhamma*, which included the idea of non-violence. **Ashoka met a Buddhist monk who taught him about Buddha's *dhamma*.** Inspired by Buddhist teachings, Ashoka set out to help the people in his empire and make sure that everyone was treated fairly. People remember him as a great ruler because he treated his people with care and kindness.

THINK

Ashoka decided to give up war because he felt regret about the bloodshed it caused at Kalinga. Have you done something and later felt regret? Did it change you in any way? Think and write about your experience in a few lines.

Ashoka fought a very long and violent war with Kalinga. In the end, **he won the battle, but it caused a lot of bloodshed and suffering.** So, even though he won, Ashoka did not feel any joy. Instead, he felt regret that the war had hurt so many people and their families. **He realised that wars only lead to pain and suffering.** That day, he decided he would not fight any more wars. **He is the only emperor in the history of the world to renounce conquest after winning a battle.**

KEYWORDS

regret: a feeling of sadness about something one has done
renounce: give up forever



Fig. 6.6: Ashoka was inspired by Buddhism.

Ashoka's Policies

How did Ashoka take care of the people in his empire? He noticed that there were some matters that created problems. People argued about which religion to follow. They often performed animal sacrifices and mistreated their servants and slaves. Ashoka believed that his subjects were his own children and that it was his responsibility to help them overcome these problems. **He introduced a set of teachings called Ashoka's *dhamma*,** which he wanted his people to follow. Let us learn more about Ashoka's *dhamma*.

Ashoka's Dhamma

What did it teach?

- It taught compassion, peace, and non-violence, not just towards other humans but also towards animals.
- It did not involve making sacrifices or worshipping a god.

How did the message spread?

- Ashoka appointed officials, known as *dhamma mahamattas*, to travel around the empire and help people understand and follow *dhamma*.
- He also sent messengers to other parts of the world, such as Syria, Egypt, Greece, and Sri Lanka.
- His teachings were inscribed as *edicts* on pillars and rocks for people to read. These are called *Ashokan edicts*.

KEYWORDS

edicts: laws or orders made or given by an authority (as a ruler)



Fig. 6.7: Places where Ashoka sent his messengers



DO YOU KNOW?

Ashoka is believed to have set up the world's first animal hospital! These not only provided medical treatment but also had rest areas and food for animals, reflecting Ashoka's deep commitment to their well-being.

Here is a translation of one such Ashokan edict.

Sometimes, people perform various rituals when certain problems happen. These rituals do not really help. Instead, people should do other things such as **being kind to those who work for them, respecting older people, being kind to all animals, and giving gifts to holy people.** It is also not good to say your religion is the best or say bad things about other religions. **Everyone should respect each other's religions and try to learn about them.**

COMMUNICATE

Look at the underlined text in the box. Which of these ideas from Ashoka's *dhamma* are important and should be followed today? Share your thoughts with your partner.

Besides the introduction of his dhamma, Ashoka introduced other changes in the Mauryan Empire. He stopped fighting wars, and the money used previously to fight battles was now used to improve people's lives. He wanted everyone to have medical care, so he built hospitals for the sick and injured. Ashoka also helped people who were poor and homeless by building shelters and homes for them and making sure they had enough food to eat.

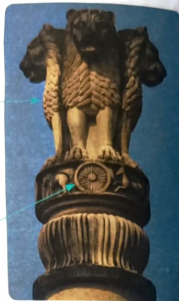
Did you know that our national emblem and the *chakra* or wheel in our national flag are based on the Ashokan pillar at Sarnath? By choosing these symbols, we, as a nation, honour Ashoka and the values he preached.



सत्यमेव जयते



Fig. 6.8: The national emblem and the *chakra* with the original carvings on the Ashokan pillar at Sarnath in Uttar Pradesh



Sources of History

We know so much about the Mauryan Empire from the study of multiple sources of history. Let us look at them.

Sources of History

Books

Arthashastra
by Chanakya

Religious Literature

Books by Jain and
Buddhist monks

Writings of Travellers

Indica, written by the Greek
traveller Megasthenes

Coins

Issued by Mauryan
emperors

Monuments

Buddhist stupas such as
the Sanchi Stupa

Inscriptions

Ashoka's edicts on
pillars and rocks

Archaeological
Sources



Fig. 6.9: Megasthenes

Of the different sources of history, two literary sources — *Indica* by Megasthenes and *Arthashastra* by Chanakya — are the richest sources of information about the Mauryan Empire.

Megasthenes was a Greek official, traveller, and historian who visited Chandragupta Maurya's court. He wrote *Indica* based on his observations and the information gathered from Indian scholars and officials. *Indica* describes Indian society, culture, religion, and politics during the Mauryan period.

Arthashastra advises kings on how to govern their people, maintain peace, and protect their kingdoms. It helps us understand how the Mauryan Empire was governed.

Besides these sources, we also learned about Ashoka's edicts on pillars and rocks. They give us important information about his dhamma, his ideas as a ruler, and the places where he tried to spread his message.

6.4 FEATURES OF THE MAURYAN EMPIRE

The Mauryan Empire was vast, stretching from present-day Afghanistan in the west to Karnataka in the south and Bengal in the east. There were several important cities in the empire, such as Pataliputra, Taxila, and Ujjain.

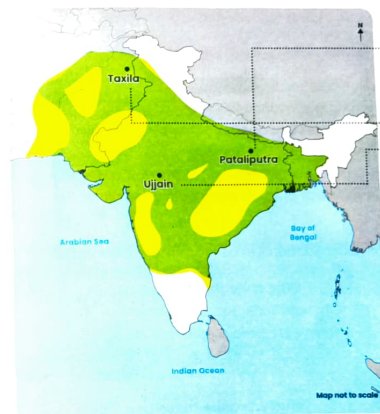


Fig. 6.11: Important cities and provincial capitals in the Mauryan Empire

Pataliputra was the capital city where the emperor and government officials lived.

Taxila and Ujjain were important cities on trade routes. They were centres of trade within and outside the empire. Many traders and craftspeople lived in these cities.

ACTIVITY 2

Look at the map in Fig. 6.11 to check if the state where you live today was a part of the Mauryan Empire.

Did you know that Taxila is now in Pakistan, while Pataliputra and Ujjain are still located in India? The modern name of Pataliputra is Patna, and it is the capital of Bihar.

Administration

The Mauryan Empire was the first to unite India politically and make the laws the same for everyone. The Mauryas created a complex system of government to manage the large empire. We know about their government from sources such as Ashoka's edicts, Megasthenes' *Indica*, and Chanakya's *Arthashastra*.

The empire was so vast that different parts had to be ruled differently.

Scan here



to learn about
the Mauryan
administration

Pataliputra and Surrounding Areas

The emperor was the most important person in the empire. He directly controlled the area around the capital city of Pataliputra. He was helped by different people such as the **mantrin parishad** (a council of ministers) and other officials. The **mantrin parishad** advised the king on important matters. The officials were responsible for collecting taxes from villages and cities.

The Provinces

The rest of the empire was divided into provinces or smaller areas. Taxila, Ujjain, Tosali, and Suvarnagiri were provincial capitals from which the provinces were governed. Royal princes were appointed as governors to these provinces. The provinces were further divided into smaller areas such as districts and villages. There were different officials at each level to help run the empire. Did you know that the Mauryan emperors also had a network of spies to find out if the different officials were doing their tasks?

Taxation

The Mauryan Empire had a well-organised system for tax collection. Let us learn more about this.

Who paid taxes?

- All farmers, herders, traders, and craftspeople paid taxes.

Who collected these taxes?

- Officials collected these taxes.
- They were paid a salary to do so.

Taxes

How were taxes paid?

- Taxes were paid in money or in kind.
- Tributes were also paid to the emperor.

What were the taxes used for?

- Taxes were used to pay for the administration of the empire and to provide for the needs of the people.

Social and Economic Life

How was life in the Mauryan Empire? What jobs did people do to earn money? How did they live? Let us find out.

Economic Life

The first thing we will explore is what jobs people did, how they earned money, and how they used it to buy or trade things they needed. This is called **economic life**.

The Empire

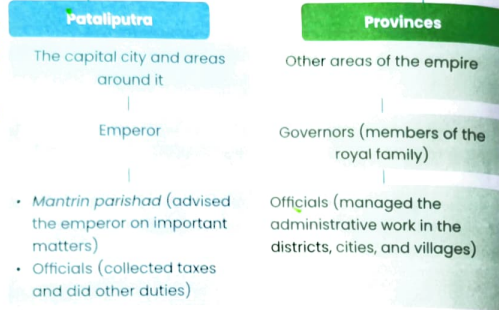


Fig. 6.12: The administration of the Mauryan Empire

KEYWORDS

Spies: people who try to get secret information about a country

We can learn about economic life in the Mauryan Empire by reading what Megasthenes wrote. Pay attention to the words in bold.

When I visited the Mauryan Empire, I saw how wealthy it was. I talked to many people to learn about their lives. I wanted to find out how they made a living. **Most people were farmers** who lived in villages and grew different crops such as rice, wheat, and fruits. Some were **rich traders**, and others were **skilled craftspeople** who lived in cities. **Everyone had a job and earned enough money to live well.**

The government helped people in different ways to do their jobs. It provided money to build dams and reservoirs and also supported trade with other countries.



Fig. 6.13: Traders in the Mauryan Empire

We have read that people in the Mauryan Empire had different jobs such as farming, trading, and working as craftspeople. The Mauryan rulers helped them in many ways.

- They cleared forests for farming.
- They built water tanks and dams to provide water for farming.
- They helped traders to trade with other countries.

Craftspeople belonged to guilds called **shrenis** that helped and protected them. Different types of crafts had different **shrenis**. These also helped to solve any problems that the craftspeople faced.

Social Life

Let us learn about the social life of the people in the Mauryan Empire. **Social life** includes how people lived in families, the customs they followed, the festivals they celebrated, and the religions they followed. Read the boxes given below to understand what the *Indica* tells us about social life in this period.

Social Life

Religious Life

- Most people followed the Vedic religion.
- The **varna system** was followed strictly.
- Many people were **Buddhists and Jains**.

Family Life

- Family was a very important unit in society.
- People lived in joint families.

Role of Women

- Women were treated with **respect**.
- They were allowed to **own property**.
- Women did not have the same position or rights as men.

Decline of the Mauryan Empire

The Mauryan Empire was one of the largest and most powerful empires in ancient India. However, eventually declined and collapsed due to several reasons.

Weak rulers: After the death of Emperor Ashoka, the Mauryan Empire was ruled by a series of weak rulers who were unable to maintain the unity and stability of the empire. Many parts of the empire broke away to form smaller kingdoms.

Size of the empire: The Mauryan Empire was very large and needed a lot of money and resources. Weak rulers were unable to collect enough resources to rule the empire well.

External invasions: The Mauryan Empire faced several invasions from foreign powers such as the Sakas (a group from present-day Iran). This weakened the empire's military strength.

These factors led to the decline of the Mauryan Empire and its eventual collapse. The last Mauryan ruler was killed by his own general in 185 BCE, marking the end of the empire.

KEYWORDS

stability: the ability to continue without change
external invasions: attacks by foreign kingdoms or empires

LET'S REVISE

Periodisation

- Historians organise the past into three periods based on features like the beliefs of the people, social structures, or the ruling powers at that time.
- These periods are:
 - The ancient period: Prehistoric – around 700 CE
 - The medieval period: Around 700 CE – around 1700 CE
 - The modern period: 1700 CE – present

The Mauryan Empire

- India's first empire
- Established by Chandragupta Maurya in 321 BCE under the guidance of Chanakya
- Important rulers – Chandragupta Maurya, Bindusara, and Ashoka
- Important sources of history – the Arthashastra, the Indica, and Ashokan edicts
- Important cities – Pataliputra, Taxila, and Ujjain

Ashoka the Great

- The most important of all the Mauryan emperors
- Vowed to stop fighting battles after the war with Kalinga
- Introduced dhamma to spread peace and harmony in his empire

Administration and Social and Economic Life

- Empire divided into provinces
- Ruled from Pataliputra by the emperor, the most powerful person in the empire
- Other important people – *mantrin* *parishad*, officials, and members of the royal family
- Important jobs – farming, herding, trading, and working as craftspeople
- Religions followed – the Vedic religion, Buddhism, and Jainism

EXERCISES

A. Fill in the blanks.

- An Empire is a large area of land, bigger than a kingdom.
- Ashoka fought a very long and violent war with Kalinga, which resulted in many deaths.
- Ashoka introduced a set of teachings called dhamma to improve the lives of his people.
- In the Mauryan Empire, the capital city and areas around it were controlled by the emperor.
- Craftspeople belonged to guilds called shrenis which supported and protected them. (*corporations*)

B. Choose the correct answer.

- Which period of history comes after the ancient period?
(a) Prehistoric (b) Written (c) ☒ Medieval (d) Modern
- In which year did Chandragupta Maurya come to power?
(a) ☒ 321 BCE (b) 300 BCE (c) 310 BCE (d) 330 BCE
- Which type of historical source is the Sanchi Stupa?
(a) Book (b) ☒ Monument (c) Coin (d) Inscription
- Where did the emperor and government officials live in the Mauryan Empire?
(a) Ujjain (b) Taxila (c) ☒ Pataliputra (d) Kalinga
- Which of the following was NOT a reason for the decline of the Mauryan Empire?
(a) Weak rulers (b) Size of the empire (c) External invasions (d) ☒ Ashoka's dhamma

C. Write True or False. Rewrite the false statements correctly in your notebook

- Historians divide the past into the following periods, starting from the oldest: the modern period, the ancient period, and the medieval period. False.
- Ashoka was the son of Chandragupta Maurya. False
- Ashoka's dhamma encouraged animal sacrifices as a part of its teachings. False
- Arthashastra by Chanakya provides advice on how to govern, maintain peace, and protect kingdoms. True
- The women in the empire were not allowed to own property. False.

D. Answer the following questions in brief:

- Why do historians divide history into different periods?
- List any two differences between a kingdom and an empire.
- Describe the events that led to the rise of the Mauryan Empire.
- Explain the term 'dynasty' using the example of the Mauryan Empire. *rule by blood relation*
- 'Pataliputra, Taxila, and Ujjain were important cities in the Mauryan Empire.' Explain why. *recapital*
- Who paid taxes in the Mauryan Empire? What were these taxes used for?

E. Answer the following questions in detail:

- What were some teachings of Ashoka's dhamma? Why did he introduce them?
- Explain how Ashoka spread his message of dhamma.
- 'The Mauryan Empire was so vast that different parts had to be ruled differently.' Explain how the Mauryan Empire was governed.

4. Explain each of the following aspects of life in the Mauryan Empire:
 - (a) Role of *shrenis*
 - (b) Farming in the empire
 - (c) The *varna* system
5. Explain the reasons for the decline of the Mauryan Empire.

Map Work

1. On an outline map of India, locate and label the following:
 - (a) Extent of the Mauryan Empire
 - (b) Pataliputra
 - (c) Taxila
 - (d) Ujjain

HOTS — Think and answer.

1. Imagine you are Emperor Ashoka. Write a diary entry in not more than five sentences on how you feel after the war with Kalinga.
2. Historians call Ashoka 'Ashoka the Great'. After learning about his rule, do you think this title is appropriate? Give reasons to support your answer.

Competency-based questions

1. Read the text given in the boxes below. For each text, answer the questions that follow.

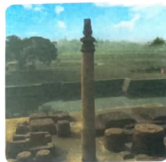
Text A

The kingdom is as beautiful as Greece.
The people are happy and respect
their ruler.

Text B

The emperor is the most powerful person. He
should take care of his subjects. He can collect
revenue from the people to run the empire.

- (a) Identify the literary source it has been taken from and the author.
 - (b) List one thing it tells us about the Mauryan Empire.
2. Look at the pictures and answer the questions below.
 - (a) What type of historical source is shown?
 - (b) Explain why this source was important in Ashoka's kingdom. How did it help unite his people?
 - (c) Can you think of any modern ways leaders share important messages with people today?



REFLECTIONS

1. What is one interesting thing that you learned in this chapter and will remember for a long time?

2. Go back to the questions you listed at the beginning of the chapter. What answers have you found?



Tapestry of the Past

7/4/20

7. India in the Iron Age



IN THIS CHAPTER, YOU WILL ...

- Learn about the kingdoms that emerged in India after the decline of the Mauryan Empire.
- Learn about the larger changes that took place in India during the Iron Age.

CONNECTIONS TO OUR LIFE

- Many changes from the Iron Age, like new technology and trade, still affect our lives today.
- Several modern cities that exist even today began to emerge during the Iron Age.

BIG IDEA

The Iron Age in India saw developments in technology, growth of new cities, new and changes in culture.

LET'S BEGIN

Through our study of the past, we have seen an evolution in the lifestyle of humans – from hunting and gathering to settled farming villages, small kingdoms, and finally, large empires.

Why did these changes take place? One major reason was technology. The tools of the Stone Age helped humans shift towards farming. The stronger metal tools of the Bronze Age allowed complex civilisations to develop. Naturally, when iron began to be used during the Iron Age, significant changes followed. Let us do an activity to recall them.

ACTIVITY 1

How did the simple iron plough lead to the emergence of large cities in ancient India? Fill in the blanks to recall.

- The iron plough helped farmers to plough the land.
- This meant that more people were free to do other work such as city-building.
- Some large villages grew into kingdoms.
- People living in cities did different types of work such as crafting.
- Some cities in the Mauryan Empire were Tamil, Varanasi, Luján.

Although the Iron Age started around 1200 BCE, it was the period from 500 BCE onwards that major changes began to take place. In this chapter, we will explore the major developments of this period. We will learn about the kingdoms that rose after the fall of the Mauryan Empire and the significant changes that took place in India during the Iron Age.

7.1 INDIA – NEW KINGDOMS AND EMPIRES

Major changes started to take place in India after the fall of the Mauryan Empire. This period is also called the post-Mauryan period. In this period, no single ruler controlled all of India. Instead, several new powers and kingdoms emerged in different parts of the country.

Sources

Before we learn about the new kingdoms, we must ask ourselves how we know about these developments. Although there are many important sources from this period, such as coins and statues, we will look at two in particular: *Sangam* literature and the writings of travellers.

Sangam Literature

In the period between 300 BCE and 300 CE, Tamil poets held three meetings in Madurai. These meetings were known as *sangams*, and this period is known as the **Sangam Age**. The poems written in these meetings together form the *Sangam* literature. This literature provides valuable insights into the period's kings, society, and culture.



Fig. 7.1: A page from a Sangam manuscript

Accounts of Travellers

Many travellers visited India during this period and wrote about their experiences. For example, the accounts of Chinese Buddhist pilgrims, such as Fa Xian, help us learn about the lives of common people as well as the rulers.



Fig. 7.2: A portrait of Fa Xian

Post-Mauryan Kingdoms

The Kushanas (50 CE–300 CE)

After the decline of the Mauryas, North India saw the rise of new dynasties. Foreign tribes from Central Asia entered India through the mountains and conquered parts of northwestern India. One such tribe was the Kushanas, who built a strong empire in northwestern India.

- The Kushana Empire included large parts of Afghanistan, Pakistan, and northern India.
- Kanishka was their most important ruler. He became a follower of Buddhism.
- The Kushanas controlled parts of an important trade route, called the Silk Route, that connected China with Europe. This helped the empire become wealthy from trade. We will learn about the Silk Route later in this chapter.



Fig. 7.3: A coin with a picture of Kanishka

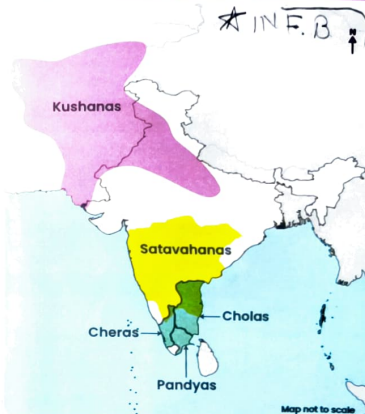


Fig. 7.4: A map of the post-Mauryan kingdoms

The Satavahanas (100 BCE–200 CE)

In the Deccan region of India, the Satavahana kingdom emerged.

- The Satavahanas were a powerful clan during the Mauryan period. After the Mauryan Empire declined, they built their own kingdom in western and southern India.
- Gautamiputra Satakarni was an important ruler of the Satavahana Empire.
- The Satavahana kings ruled over the Deccan for nearly 300 years and were known as the 'Lords of Dakshinapatha', which means 'the route leading to the south'.
- They traded with far-off places like Bengal and even the Roman Empire, which was a large empire in present-day Europe.



Fig. 7.5: A coin with a picture of Gautamiputra Satakarni

The Cholas, the Cheras, and the Pandyas (400 BCE–300 CE)

In the south, three kingdoms or ruling dynasties emerged: the Cholas, the Cheras, and the Pandyas.

- Together, these three dynasties were called the *muvendar* or the three great kings.
- They ruled over a large region known as Tamizhagam, covering present-day Tamil Nadu and Kerala.
- The kingdoms were well known for their trade, which took place over land and sea. Cities such as Kaveripattinam, Arikamedu, and Korkai were busy ports. Evidence of trade relations with the Romans has also been found. Locate these cities on the map in Fig. 7.9 on Pg. 101.
- The three kingdoms flourished during the Sangam Age between the third century BCE and the third century CE.



Fig. 7.6: A coin from the Sangam Age

7.2 GROWTH OF TECHNOLOGY, TRADE, AND CITIES

In the last section, we learned about the political changes that were taking place as new kingdoms rose in different parts of India. At the same time, significant developments were also happening in the fields of technology and trade, leading to the growth of cities.

Technology

We have seen that the growth of technology defined major periods of human history — from the Stone Age to the Bronze Age and the Iron Age. In the Iron Age, people used iron to develop stronger and better tools. The iron tools, along with other technological developments, led to improvements in agriculture.

Agricultural Technologies



Iron ploughs helped to turn the soil better, and iron axes were used to clear forests for cultivation.



Irrigation facilities, such as wells, canals, and tanks, made it easy to water crops even in dry seasons.



People began to transplant paddy (rice). This helped more crops to survive.

Other Technologies

Besides agriculture, technological advancements were also seen in other aspects. These included the following:

Iron weapons, such as swords, spears, and arrows, were developed in the Iron Age in India. They gave some armies a significant advantage over others who were still using bronze weapons.

Punch-marked coins were some of the earliest coins used in India, right from the Mauryan period. These coins were made of silver, copper, or a combination of both metals. They were cut from metals and stamped with various symbols using the hammer-and-punch method. They were used by traders to pay taxes to rulers. In this period, the quality of metal coins improved further, as can be seen in the coin in Fig. 7.3 on Pg. 97.

KEYWORDS

canals, pathways dug in the ground to bring water to crops
transplant, to move a young plant from one location to another to allow it to grow and develop better



Trade

Today, if we look carefully at many of the clothes or other items we use, we might see tags that say 'Made in China', 'Made in Bangladesh', or 'Made in the USA'. How are we able to use products that were made in far-off places? The answer to this is trade.

Trade in India existed as far back as the Bronze Age civilisations, as seals of the Indus Civilisation were found in Mesopotamia. During the Vedic Age, however, trade with faraway places declined as most villages traded only with each other. But by 200 BCE, trade began to flourish again.

India was rich in spices, precious stones, and cloth, which were in great demand in Europe and other parts of the world. Traders would come to India by land and sea routes to buy and sell goods. One such network of trade routes was the Silk Route.



Fig. 7.7 Precious stones (left) and spices (right) were sent from India to Rome. Pepper was so expensive that it was known as 'black gold' in the Roman Empire.

Silk Route

Today, we can buy silk cloth in any market. But thousands of years ago, it was not so easy. Only the Chinese knew how to make silk, and they kept this knowledge a secret. People in other parts of the world wanted to buy silk and were willing to pay a lot of money for it. So, traders travelled by land and sea to China and brought silk to different countries to sell. The network of routes that the traders used to transport silk came to be known as the Silk Route.

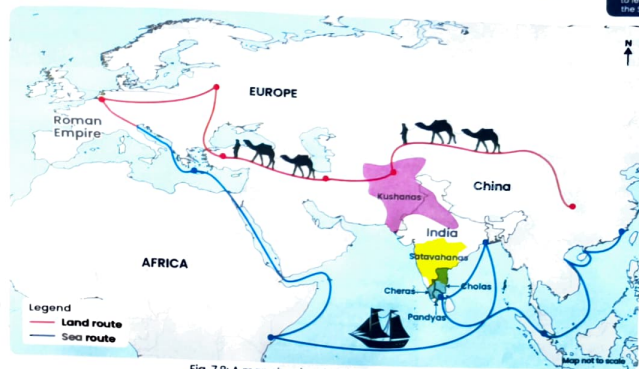


Fig. 7.8 A map showing the Silk Route used for trade

As you can see from the map in Fig. 7.8, the Silk Route connected China with Europe. To travel between these places, traders had to pass through India. The land route passed through northern India, which was ruled by the Kushanas. The sea route passed through southern India, which was under the control of the Cholas, the Cheras, and the Pandya.

The rulers of these kingdoms would demand taxes from traders to allow them to pass. Traders would also give gifts to the rulers in exchange for protection from thieves. As a result, the Indian kingdoms gained a lot of wealth from the Silk Route, making it very beneficial for them.

DID YOU KNOW?

One of the greatest inventions that travelled along the Silk Route was paper. It was invented in China and spread to other parts of Asia and Europe, changing the way people wrote and recorded information!

But the story does not end here. Imagine that you were living in one of the Indian cities through which traders, carrying silk and other foreign goods, would pass. What do you think you might have done? You might have wanted to buy some of these items. You may also have wanted to sell some items, such as spices and precious stones, which were in high demand in faraway lands! This is exactly what happened. Indian rulers and traders also started to engage in trade with the passing traders. This further developed the economy, making the kingdoms extremely prosperous.

The cities through which the traders passed developed large markets and became centres for trade. We will learn about some of these cities in the next section.

Although trade started with silk, many other items were also traded along the route. Apart from goods, the Silk Route also helped in the exchange of ideas, religions, and cultures. We will learn about this later in this chapter.

Cities

We have learned about the first cities in India, such as Harappa and Mohenjodaro. After the decline of the Indus Civilisation, the people of the Vedic Age largely lived in villages. It was with the rise of the mahajanapadas that towns and cities started to emerge again. From around 400 BCE, the growth in agricultural production and trade led to the rise of several cities. This has come to be known as the second urbanisation in India.

Today, when we look at the different cities in India, we see that they have multiple functions. For example, New Delhi is the capital of India, but it is also known for its markets and historical sites. But many of the new cities that emerged in the Iron Age often had specific functions:

Administrative Cities

The capital cities of kingdoms became the centres of administration. These included Pataliputra (capital of the Mauryan Empire) and Kaveripattinam (the Chola capital).



Religious Centres

Religion and worship remained important aspects of the lives of people. Some towns and cities that had many temples or religious places became temple towns where people went for a pilgrimage. Kashi (present-day Varanasi) and Vaishali were some important temple towns of this period, which exist to this day.



Types of Cities in the Iron Age

Port Cities

These were towns and cities where ships arrived from faraway lands. Ships carrying goods, merchants, and traders needed ports to load and unload goods and people. Towns and cities eventually developed around these ports. These were called port cities. Bharuch, Korkai, and Arikamedu were some of the important port cities.



KEYWORDS

urbanisation: the process of villages developing into cities or people from villages moving into cities

COMMUNICATE

Imagine you are an official in the Kushana Empire. The Silk Route passes through the empire, but the new emperor wants to shut it down. Write a letter to the emperor to convince him to keep the route open. Give at least two reasons why this route is beneficial to the Kushana Empire.

Cities with Multiple Functions

Some cities also had multiple functions. For example, Mathura was both the capital of the Kushanas and an important city for trade. Similarly, in the south, Madurai served as both the capital city of the Pandyas and an important centre for trade.

CONNECT TO LIFE

Take help from your parents or any other elderly person in your family or neighbourhood to learn more about your city or town. Find out the answers to the following questions:

1. How old is it?
2. What type of town or city is it?
3. Did it have another name in the past?



Fig. 7.9: A map showing cities that emerged during the second urbanisation in India

7.3 LIFE IN THE IRON AGE IN INDIA

Besides political and technological developments, the Iron Age in India also saw several important developments in the lifestyle of the people. With more powerful kingdoms, trade, and cities emerging, the economic and social lives of people also grew more complex.

Economic Life

The new kingdoms needed taxes to run. Who paid these taxes? It was the common people who did different types of work. Let us learn about some of them.

Agriculture continued to be the main occupation of most people. The technological developments meant that farmers could now produce more food and feed more people in villages and cities. This also freed up other people to take up new jobs.



Crafts began to grow at this time.

Stone and metal workers were in high demand. There were also carpenters, weavers, sculptors, and jewellers. Potters developed a special kind of pottery during this time, known as Northern Black Polished Ware. Its name comes from the fact that it was black in colour and had a shine on the surface.



Fig. 7.10: A piece of Northern Black Polished Ware



Trade became an important activity, as we can see from the rise of many market and port cities. The crafts and cloth made in India were sold in Rome and other parts of Asia. Better roads made it easier for traders and merchants to travel from one place to another, and market cities provided space to sell their goods. Traders and merchants grew wealthy over time.



Craft and Trade Guilds

In the last chapter, we learned that craftspeople were a part of groups known as guilds or *shrenis*. As trade developed, trade guilds were also formed. These guilds supported craftspeople and traders by providing them with raw materials and helping them sell their goods.

Social Life

Social Classes in Villages

While many new cities emerged during this period, a large number of people still lived and worked in villages. However, not everyone in the village was equal. Social groups began to emerge, often based on the amount of land owned by a person. Let us read about the different social groups and their names across North India and South India.

► Village Groups in North India

Grama bhojakas: Village headmen; owned the most land; collected taxes



Grihapatis: Independent farmers; owned smaller lands



Dasa karmakara: Landless labourers; worked in the fields of grama bhojakas and grihapatis



► Village Groups in South India

Vellalar: Rich, powerful landowners



Uzhavar: Ordinary farmers



Kadaiyyar and adimai: Landless labourers and slaves



Thus, the people who owned the most land had the highest power in the villages. The poorer, landless labourers had no choice but to work on other people's lands.

Spread of New Ideas, Culture, and Religion

The Silk Route did not just enable the movement of goods. When traders from different parts of the world met, they would talk to each other about their lives. Over time, this led to an exchange of ideas and cultures. Even religions, such as Buddhism and Christianity, spread along the Silk Route.



Fig. 7.11: A painting of Buddha from this period

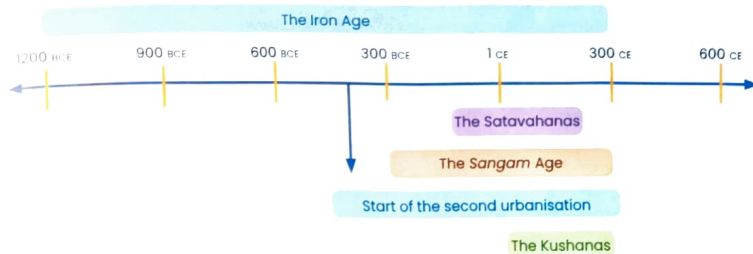
A new form of Buddhism, Mahayana Buddhism, became prominent during the reign of Kanishka. In older Buddhist structures, such as the Sanchi Stupa, Buddha was shown in other forms, such as a banyan tree or an elephant. In Mahayana Buddhism, people began to worship idols or images of Buddha. They also worshipped *bodhisattvas* or wise teachers who had attained enlightenment. This new form of Buddhism spread to Central Asia and East Asia through the Silk Route.

Besides traders, pilgrims frequently used the Silk Route to visit holy places associated with their religions. The spread of Buddhism brought many Chinese pilgrims to India.



Scan here
to learn about the
spread of ideas
through the Silk
Route

LET'S REVISE



The Iron Age in India

Kingdoms	Technology, Trade, and Cities	Economic and Social Life
Some important kingdoms that emerged during this time were		
- the Kushanas in the north, - the Satavahanas in the Deccan, and - the Cholas, the Cheras, and the Pandyas in the south.	- The use of iron tools improved agricultural production. - The emergence of the Silk Route improved trade. - New types of cities emerged with specific functions.	- New occupations emerged. - Social classes developed in villages. - Trade routes led to the spread of new ideas, cultures, and religions.

EXERCISES

A. Fill in the blanks.

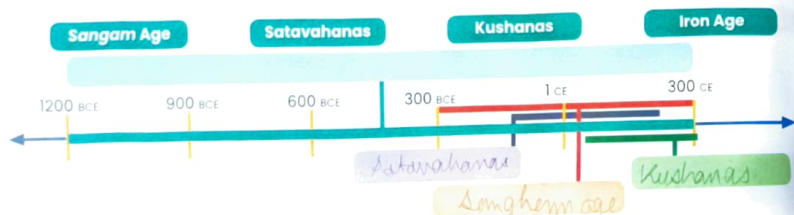
- The _____ Age saw Tamil poets hold three meetings in Madurai.
- ~~Xiao~~ _____ was a Chinese pilgrim who wrote about life in the post-Mauryan period.
- Together, the dynasties of the Cholas, the Cheras, and the Pandyas were called the _____.
- The network of routes that the traders used to transport silk came to be known as the _____.
- The rise of cities during the Iron Age is called the second _____ in India.

B. Choose the correct answer.

- Which kingdom's rulers were known as the 'Lords of Dakshinapatha'?
(a) The Cheras (b) The Satavahanas
(c) The Kushanas (d) The Pandyas
- Which technology made it easier to turn the soil in the Iron Age?
(a) Iron ploughs (b) Irrigation
(c) Transplantation (d) Punched-marked coins
- Which kind of pottery developed during the Iron Age in India?
(a) Red Clay Ware (b) Blue Glazed Pottery
(c) Northern Black Polished Ware (d) Southern Stoneware
- Which dynasty ruled the empire in northwestern India through which the Silk Route passed?
(a) The Satavahanas (b) The Cholas
(c) The Pandyas (d) The Kushanas
- Which of the following is an example of a city that had multiple functions?
(a) Ujjain (b) Kashi
(c) Mathura (d) Pataliputra

C. Answer the following questions about the kingdoms of India that emerged in the Iron Age:

- Identify the kingdom(s) in each case.
(a) The kingdom in the north that had a famous ruler named Kanishka *The Kushanas*
(b) The kingdom in the Deccan whose kings were known as the 'Lords of Dakshinapatha' *Satavahanas*
(c) The three kingdoms of the south that flourished in the Sangam Age *Cholas, Pandyas, Cheras*
- Mark and label each of these kingdoms on an outline map of India.
- Arrange the following kingdoms and historical periods on the timeline given below:



D. Answer the following questions in brief:

- What sources help us learn about the kingdoms that came after the Mauryan period?
- Who were the Kushanas, and where did they come from?
- Describe any two technological developments that took place in agriculture during the Iron Age.
- What was the Silk Route?
- Describe two types of cities that emerged in India during the Iron Age.

E. Answer the following questions in detail:

- Write a short note on any of the post-Mauryan kingdoms.
- Besides agriculture, what were some other technological advancements in the Iron Age in India?
- What were the different jobs people did in the Iron Age in India? Why did these jobs emerge?
- 'All the people in the villages of North India had the same amount of power.' Do you agree or disagree with this statement? Justify your answer.
- How did the Silk Route help in the spread of new ideas and religions?

F. HOTS – Think and answer.

- 'The Iron Age shows the importance of trade in bringing about prosperity.' Give reasons for this statement.
- Imagine that you lived during the Early Vedic Age. One day, you got a chance to use a time machine that took you to the Iron Age in India. Describe the changes that you are likely to see. What new things would amaze you?

G. Competency-based questions

- Imagine you are travelling through different cities in India during the Iron Age. Identify the type of city from the following descriptions:
(a) This city is full of traders and merchants selling goods. *market city*
(b) In this city, you notice many ships transporting goods along the coast. *port city*
(c) You see crowds of people waiting to visit a famous temple in the city. *religious city*
- Read the following scenario and answer the questions given below:
Imagine you are a trader travelling by land along the Silk Route. You have just arrived in the Kushana Empire. Here, you meet many other traders, with whom you exchange not only goods but also ideas and cultures.
(a) What are some of the goods you would be selling and buying here? *silk, spices, precious stones*
(b) What are some ideas you might exchange? *new ideas and agricultural products*
(c) Write a paragraph describing a day from your life. *religious ideas, cultural ideas, agricultural techniques*

REFLECTIONS

- What is one thing you learned about the Iron Age in India that you found the most interesting?
- In history, we learn about many changes that have taken place in our world and country over a long period of time. How can people today keep track of these changes?